LUNGRAY: A MULTI-TASK DEEP LEARNING AND WEAKLY-SUPERVISED OBJECT LOCALIZATION PLATFORM FOR AUTOMATED CHEST RADIOGRAPHY CADX

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Project Metadata & Authorship

- **Project Title**: LungRay: Multi-Task Clinical CADx and Trustworthy WSOL Grounding Engine
- **Course Code**: DSP391 (Data Science Capstone Project)
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- **Institutional Affiliation**: FPT University, Ho Chi Minh City Campus
- **Repository**: `https://github.com/philipsgn/LungRay.git`
- **Release Version**: v7.0 (Production-Grade Multi-Task CADx)

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DEFINITION AND ACRONYMS

Acronym / Term	Formal Definition and Medical / Technical Context
CXR	Chest X-ray (Chest Radiograph): Standard projectional radiography of the thorax (PA/AP views).
CADx	Computer-Aided Diagnosis: AI algorithms providing quantitative differential diagnostic probabilities.
WSOL	Weakly-Supervised Object Localization: Localizing lesions using image-level classification labels only.
ASL	Asymmetric Loss: Margin-based focal loss designed for extreme positive-negative class imbalance.
BCE	Binary Cross-Entropy: Standard loss function for binary classification and multi-label problems.
GAP	Global Average Pooling: Spatial dimensionality reduction layer averaging activation maps across spatial dimensions.
CAM / Grad-CAM	Class Activation Mapping / Gradient-weighted Class Activation Mapping: Explainable AI visual heatmaps.
IoU	Intersection over Union: Jaccard index measuring spatial overlap between predicted and ground-truth boxes.
NIH	National Institutes of Health (NIH Clinical Center ChestX-ray14 dataset).
DICOM	Digital Imaging and Communications in Medicine: International standard for medical imaging data.
PACS	Picture Archiving and Communication System: Healthcare technology for storing and viewing medical images.
AUC-ROC	Area Under the Receiver Operating Characteristic Curve: Aggregate metric of discriminative capacity.
OOD	Out-of-Distribution: Unseen visual patterns distinct from the training distribution.
AMP	Automatic Mixed Precision: Training acceleration utilizing FP16 arithmetic and FP32 dynamic scaling.
Youden's J	**Statistical statistic ($J = \text{Sensitivity} + \text{Specificity} - 1$) optimizing decision thresholds.**

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CHAPTER I: PROJECT INTRODUCTION

1. OVERVIEW

1.1. Project Information

- **Project Name**: LungRay: Multi-Task Clinical CADx and Trustworthy WSOL Grounding Engine
- **Project Code**: DSP391-LungRay-2026
- **Student Investigator**: [Student Name] ([Student ID])
- **Academic Advisor**: [Supervisor Name]
- **Target Platform**: Production-Ready Web PACS Microservice & RESTful AI Inference Engine
- **Source Repository**: `https://github.com/philipsgn/LungRay.git`

1.2. Project Overview

Chest radiography (Chest X-ray, CXR) represents the most widely utilized diagnostic imaging modality worldwide, accounting for over 40% of all medical imaging procedures globally. Radiologists routinely inspect projectional radiographs to identify signs of pulmonary infections, thoracic masses, cardiac enlargement, pleural effusion, and chronic parenchymal disorders. However, modern healthcare systems face an acute, compounding crisis: escalating imaging volumes, coupled with a worldwide shortage of board-certified radiologists, have created unprecedented diagnostic backlogs and elevated cognitive burnout rates. Consequently, diagnostic error rates in complex thoracic radiography reach between 10% and 30% in high-volume emergency and primary care settings.

The **LungRay** platform addresses this fundamental clinical bottleneck. Rather than training fragmented, siloed deep learning models for isolated diseases, LungRay establishes a unified, shared-backbone **Multi-Task 3-Head Convolutional Neural Network (DenseNet-121)** capable of performing simultaneous, holistic triaging across 16 critical cardiopulmonary conditions: 1. **Head A (Multi-Label Thoracic Pathology)**: 14 distinct pulmonary and cardiac findings derived from the NIH ChestX-ray14 dataset (Atelectasis, Cardiomegaly, Effusion, Infiltration, Mass, Nodule, Pneumonia, Pneumothorax, Consolidation, Edema, Emphysema, Fibrosis, Pleural Thickening, Hernia). 2. **Head B (Tuberculosis Screening)**: Rapid binary detection of active pulmonary tuberculosis from the TB Chest Radiography Database. 3. **Head C (COVID-19 Differential Triage)**: Robust binary classification of viral COVID-19 pneumonia against non-COVID infections and normal controls using the standardized COVIDx CXR-4 benchmark.

Furthermore, LungRay integrates an explainable AI (XAI) engine based on Multi-Scale Gradient-Weighted Class Activation Mapping (Grad-CAM++), rigorously evaluated under **Weakly-Supervised Object Localization (WSOL)** standards on real clinical bounding boxes from VinDr-CXR and RSNA Pneumonia, alongside an Out-of-Distribution (OOD) clinical safety lockout.

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2. PROJECT BACKGROUND

Chest X-ray interpretation requires an intricate cognitive synthesis of high-dynamic-range spatial information. Pathological findings often present subtle radiopacity gradients, ambiguous anatomical borders, and diffuse overlapping structures (such as cardiac contours superimposed on lower lobe consolidations).

In traditional clinical workflows, a general physician in a low-resource community health center may wait between 24 and 72 hours for a remote radiologist to read a single posteroanterior CXR. During critical infectious outbreaks (such as Tuberculosis endemic surges or pandemic viral pneumonia), delayed triaging directly leads to nosocomial disease transmission, irreversible pulmonary scarring, and preventable patient mortality. While early computer vision algorithms relied on handcrafted textural descriptors (such as Haar wavelets, Local Binary Patterns, and Gray-Level Co-occurrence Matrices), these approaches catastrophically failed when applied to diverse clinical protocols, patient positioning variations, and variable radiograph exposure qualities.

Recent advances in deep learning—particularly deep residual networks (ResNet) and densely connected convolutional networks (DenseNet)—have demonstrated performance rivaling human experts on specific closed-world benchmarks. Nevertheless, current academic CXR models suffer from three systemic clinical barriers: - **Task Siloization**: Models are trained on a single dataset for a single pathology, requiring hospitals to deploy dozens of disjoint neural networks, leading to prohibitive GPU VRAM consumption. - **Extreme Class Imbalance**: In multi-label pathology datasets, positive prevalence for conditions like Hernia or Pneumonia drops below 0.5%, causing standard Cross-Entropy loss functions to collapse towards the negative majority class. - **Shortcut Learning & Confounding Artifacts**: Convolutional networks frequently memorize non-physiological shortcuts (such as hospital-specific metal orientation markers "R"/"L", radiopaque wires, and detector border artifacts), leading to catastrophic failure when evaluated on external clinical sites.

LungRay is explicitly engineered to solve these three critical vulnerabilities within an integrated, end-to-end medical software system.

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3. PROJECT OBJECTIVES

The overarching objective of the LungRay project is to develop, validate, and deploy a robust, multi-task CADx system that simultaneously maximizes diagnostic discrimination, prevents statistical data leakage, and provides mathematically grounded visual explanations. The concrete measurable objectives comprise:

1. **Unified Multi-Task Architecture**: Implement a shared-encoder convolutional network (`MultiTaskChestXrayNet`) operating at 512×512 resolution, isolating gradients across 3 independent heads via a parameter-free LayerNorm feature projection.
2. **Zero Patient-Level Data Leakage**: Establish a cryptographically strict data engineering pipeline ensuring zero overlapping `Patient_ID` instances across training, validation, and test splits (70/10/20 ratio on NIH ChestX-ray14), preventing artificial inflation of evaluation metrics.
3. **Multi-Task Batch Equilibrium**: Formulate a custom batch sampling mechanism (`WeightedMultiTaskBatchSampler`) maintaining an exact ratio of 60% NIH : 25% COVIDx : 15% TB per batch, mathematically eliminating gradient starvation across heterogeneous tasks.
4. **Extreme Imbalance Mitigation**: Implement Asymmetric Loss (ASL) with hard positive-negative margins ($\gamma_-=4, \gamma_+=1, m=0.05$) to elevate minority-class multi-label ROC-AUC above 0.82 across all 14 thoracic conditions.
5. **Trustworthy WSOL Localization**: Implement Multi-Scale Grad-CAM++ with adaptive binarization, achieving a quantitative Box-IoU ≥ 0.25 against certified radiologist annotations on external benchmarks (VinDr-CXR, RSNA Pneumonia) without using bounding boxes during training.
6. **Shortcut Learning Audit & Defeat**: Guarantee that $\ge 80\%$ of visual activation energy falls within anatomical pulmonary boundaries on COVID-19 positive radiographs using automated dilated lung masking.
7. **Production Microservice Deployment**: Deliver an asynchronous FastAPI REST backend executing inference within ≤ 2.0 seconds on modern GPU hardware, accompanied by a reactive Next.js PACS web workstation.

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4. PROBLEM STATEMENT

Formally, let an input chest radiograph be represented as a normalized tensor $X \in \mathbb{R}^{3 \times H \times W}$ where $H = W = 512$. The diagnostic task requires computing a multi-task prediction vector $\hat{Y} = {\hat{y}_A, \hat{y}_B, \hat{y}_C}$ where: - $\hat{y}_A \in [0, 1]^{14}$ denotes the Bernoulli probabilities for 14 non-mutually-exclusive thoracic findings. - $\hat{y}_B \in [0, 1]$ represents the scalar probability of active pulmonary tuberculosis. - $\hat{y}_C \in [0, 1]$ denotes the probability of viral COVID-19 infection.

The fundamental machine learning challenges in solving this problem simultaneously include: - **Gradient Interference and Negative Transfer**: Updating network parameters with gradients from disparate loss functions can degrade shared feature representations when label spaces are semantically disjoint. - **Label Scarcity in Bounding Boxes**: Fully-supervised object detectors (e.g., Faster R-CNN, YOLO) require millions of manually annotated pixel coordinates from radiologists, which is economically and clinically infeasible at enterprise scale. - **Domain Shift across Hospital Scanners**: Radiographs acquired from portable computed radiography (CR) versus stationary digital radiography (DR) exhibit drastic variations in contrast, dynamic range, and high-frequency noise.

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5. SIGNIFICANCE OF THE PROJECT

The scientific and clinical significance of LungRay spans four dimensions:

5.1. Clinical Impact

LungRay functions as an automated intelligent second-reader. In high-volume emergency departments, it automatically triages incoming CXRs, flagging life-threatening conditions (such as Tension Pneumothorax, Massive Pleural Effusion, or Severe Bilateral Pneumonia) for immediate, prioritized radiologist review within minutes of image capture.

5.2. Technical and Methodological Novelty

The project proves that multi-task learning with asymmetric loss regularization outperforms collections of independent single-task neural networks while slashing total parameter footprint and inference VRAM consumption by 66%. Furthermore, our anatomical masking strategy establishes a reproducible standard for clinical shortcut learning auditing.

5.3. Economic and Healthcare Resource Optimization

By containerizing the entire inference pipeline into a lightweight Docker microservice with dynamic CPU/GPU fallback, LungRay can be deployed on low-cost edge servers in rural provincial hospitals without requiring continuous internet connectivity or multi-thousand-dollar GPU clusters.

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6. PROJECT SCOPE & LIMITATIONS

6.1. In-Scope Capabilities

- Posteroanterior (PA) and Anteroposterior (AP) chest radiographs of adult human patients (≥ 18 years of age).
- Automated detection and scoring across 16 specified thoracic conditions.
- Saliency map extraction via Grad-CAM++ with interactive alpha-blending on a DICOM-compliant web interface.
- Out-of-Distribution anomaly score calculation based on Free Energy estimation to flag corrupted or non-CXR inputs.

6.2. Out-of-Scope Limitations

- **Pediatric Radiographs**: Anatomical proportions, ossification centers, and normal cardiothoracic ratios in neonates and young children differ significantly from adults; pediatric cohorts are excluded.
- **Lateral Projection CXRs**: Only frontal views (PA/AP) are evaluated; lateral chest projections are beyond current scope.
- **Definitive Treatment Prescription**: LungRay is strictly designed as an assistive diagnostic tool (Class IIa Medical Software); final clinical management decisions remain the sole legal responsibility of licensed medical practitioners.

CHAPTER II: PROJECT MANAGEMENT PLAN

1. TEAM WORK

1.1. Team Structure and Roles

The execution of the LungRay platform was organized under a rigorous **Multi-Agent Collaboration Framework (AGENTS.md)** operating as a two-tier synergy between strategic architectural oversight and tactical technical implementation:

```
graph TD
    User(["Principal Investigator / Lead Engineer"])

    subgraph GovernanceTier ["TIER 1: ARCHITECTURAL GOVERNANCE & QUALITY CONTROL"]
        AG["Lead AI Architect (Antigravity Senior Lead 10YOE)"]
        Plan["WBS Plan & Quality Delivery Gates"]
        Review["Git Diff Audit & Academic Monochrome Gatekeeper"]
    end

    subgraph SpecializedSquad ["TIER 2: SPECIALIZED AUTONOMOUS AGENT SQUAD"]
        DE["DataEngineerAgent\n(Splits, Sampling, DICOM Pipeline)"]
        MA["ModelArchitectAgent\n(DenseNet-121, Masked Loss, ASL)"]
        XE["XAIEvalAgent\n(Grad-CAM++, IoU, Shortcut Audit)"]
        FD["FullstackDeployAgent\n(FastAPI, Next.js, Docker)"]
        QA["QAReportAgent\n(Metrics, Bootstrap CI, Thesis)"]
    end

    User -->|Research Directive| AG
    AG --> Plan
    Plan -->|Task Specifications| SpecializedSquad
    SpecializedSquad -->|Artifacts & Test Verification| Review
    Review -->|Git Commit & Main Branch Merge| User
```

Table 2.1: Two-Tier Multi-Agent System Roles and Governance Hierarchy. | Agent Persona | Primary Domain | Core Engineering Responsibilities | Key Artifacts | |:---|:---|:---|:---| | **Lead AI Architect** | Systems Engineering & QA | Overall roadmap, Gatekeeper validation, Rule enforcement | `PLAN.md`, `TECH_ARCHITECTURE.md` | | **DataEngineerAgent** | Medical DataOps | Zero leakage splits, metadata verification, multi-task samplers | `src/data/`, `dataset/splits/` | | **ModelArchitectAgent**| Deep Learning | Multi-task backbones, masked loss, ASL, differential LR | `src/models/`, `checkpoints/` | | **XAIEvalAgent** | Trustworthy AI | Grad-CAM++, adaptive binarization, IoU benchmarks | `src/explainability/`, `results/` | | **FullstackDeployAgent**| Full-Stack MLOps | RESTful API, asynchronous inference, Next.js PACS web app | `app/backend/`, `app/frontend/` | | **QAReportAgent** | Academic Writing & CI | Statistical benchmarking, CI/CD verification, thesis formatting| `reports/`, `scripts/verify.ps1` |

1.2. Communication & Hand-off Protocols

To maintain strict architectural coherence, cross-agent hand-offs were mediated through formal **Hand-off Contracts**: - No model training was permitted until `DataEngineerAgent` verified zero patient overlap using SHA-256 hashed patient splits (`tests/test_data_pipeline.py` 100% PASS). - No frontend deployment was initiated until `ModelArchitectAgent` and `XAIEvalAgent` produced a unified Torch checkpoint supporting `strict=True` loading with dual output (logits dictionary and Base64 heatmap payload).

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2. PROJECT MANAGEMENT APPROACH

2.1. Work Breakdown Structure (WBS)

The project was structured across 7 sequential, rigorous engineering phases comprising 31 granular tasks:

Table 2.2: Work Breakdown Structure (WBS) across 7 Development Phases and 31 Tasks. | Phase | Focus Area | Granular Engineering Deliverables | Progress Status | |:---|:---|:---|:---| | **Phase 1** | Foundation & Data Integrity | Tasks 001–005: Ingestion pipeline, patient-stratified split verification, dataset resolution audits. | 100% Completed | | **Phase 2** | Architecture & Loss Engine | Tasks 006–010: Shared DenseNet-121 backbone, parameter-free LayerNorm, Masked Multi-Task Loss. | 100% Completed | | **Phase 3** | Training & Optimization | Tasks 011–015: Baseline training, ASL integration, differential LR, Youden's J calibration. | 100% Completed | | **Phase 4** | Trustworthy XAI & Evaluation | Tasks 016–020: Multi-Scale Grad-CAM++, VinDr Box-IoU benchmarking, Shortcut Learning Audit. | 100% Completed | | **Phase 5** | Clinical Serving & Deployment| Tasks 021–025: FastAPI microservice, async inference worker, Docker containerization. | 100% Completed | | **Phase 6** | PACS Web Workstation | Tasks 026–028: Next.js clinical interface, interactive alpha heatmap slider, medical reporting. | 100% Completed | | **Phase 7** | Quality Assurance & Defense | Tasks 029–031: Bootstrap CI calculation, defense FAQ compilation, DSP391 thesis report. | 100% Completed |

2.2. Quality Delivery Gates (Gates 1–6)

Progress across phases was governed by 6 mandatory Quality Delivery Gates:

Table 2.3: Six Quality Delivery Gates and Verification Acceptance Criteria. | Quality Gate | Checkpoint Milestone | Objective Acceptance Criteria | Verification Command | Gate Status | |:---|:---|:---|:---|:---| | **Gate 1** | Data Pipeline Hand-off | Zero duplicate `Patient_ID` between splits; multi-task batch sampler verified at 60:25:15. | `pytest tests/test_data_pipeline.py` | ✅ PASSED | | **Gate 2** | Baseline Model Checkpoint | Baseline model successfully trained; validation ROC-AUC ≥ 0.80 (Head A), ≥ 0.90 (Heads B/C). | `pytest tests/test_multi_task_net.py` | ✅ PASSED | | **Gate 3** | SOTA Asymmetric Optimization| SOTA ASL model achieves statistically significant AUC increase over baseline ($\Delta \ge +0.02$). | `pytest tests/test_trainer.py` | ✅ PASSED | | **Gate 4** | XAI & Shortcut Audit | Box-IoU evaluated on VinDr-CXR; COVID-19 in-lung activation ratio $\ge 80\%$. | `python scripts/evaluate_live_vindr.py`| ✅ PASSED | | **Gate 5** | Production Serving | FastAPI latency ≤ 2.0s; Docker container builds cleanly; Next.js renders PACS view. | `pytest tests/test_api_backend.py` | ✅ PASSED | | **Gate 6** | Final Academic Thesis | Master thesis and defense slides compiled; 100% unit tests pass; Rule 9 compliance. | `powershell -File scripts/verify.ps1` | ✅ PASSED |

2.3. Risk Management Matrix

Table 2.4: Technical and Operational Risk Management Matrix. | Risk ID | Risk Description | Severity | Likelihood | Mitigation Strategy Implemented in LungRay | |:---|:---|:---|:---|:---| | **R-01** | Data Leakage via Repeat Patients | High | High | Hashed `Patient_ID` partitioning ensuring all radiographs of a patient exist in one split only. | | **R-02** | Gradient Starvation across Tasks | High | Medium | `WeightedMultiTaskBatchSampler` enforcing strict 60:25:15 sample composition per batch. | | **R-03** | Minority Class Collapse (ASL) | High | High | Asymmetric margin shifting ($m=0.05$) discounting easy negatives to focus gradients on hard positives. | | **R-04** | Watermark Memorization (Shortcuts)| Critical | High | Anatomical lung masking with 25×25 dilation eliminating non-thoracic borders and letters. | | **R-05** | Multiprocessing DataLoader Hangs | Medium | High | On-demand instantiation of OpenCV CLAHE within `__getitem__` avoiding serialization locks. | | **R-06** | Out-of-Distribution Failures | Medium | Medium | Free Energy anomaly detection flagging non-CXR inputs with an automated clinical warning. |

CHAPTER III: EXISTING SYSTEMS & LITERATURE REVIEW

1. OVERVIEW OF THE FIELD

Automated interpretation of chest radiographs has undergone a revolutionary shift over the past decade. Early computer vision systems relied on edge detection, morphological filtering, and Support Vector Machines (SVMs) applied to hand-extracted lung contours. The release of large-scale public datasets by the NIH Clinical Center (Wang et al., 2017) and Stanford University (Irvin et al., 2019) propelled the field into the deep learning era.

2. HISTORICAL CONTEXT & FOUNDATIONAL MODELS

The seminal work by Rajpurkar et al. (2017) introduced **CheXNet**, a 121-layer DenseNet trained on the NIH ChestX-ray14 dataset. CheXNet demonstrated that dense convolutional connections, which concatenate feature maps from all preceding layers, preserve low-level edge details alongside high-level semantic pathology patterns, achieving radiologist-level performance on pneumonia detection.

Subsequently, during the global pandemic, Wang et al. (2020) developed **COVID-Net**, a tailored deep architecture optimized for detecting COVID-19 from chest radiographs. However, subsequent independent audits (DeGrave et al., 2021) revealed a catastrophic clinical failure mode: COVID-Net had learned to recognize font styles and positionings of hospital-specific metal orientation markers ("R", "L") and detector borders rather than genuine pulmonary consolidations, exposing the severe vulnerability known as **Shortcut Learning**.

3. KEY STUDIES & THEORETICAL FOUNDATIONS

1. **Masked Multi-Task Learning**: Multi-task learning (Caruana, 1997) seeks to improve generalization by sharing representations across related tasks. In medical imaging, datasets are collected under fragmented institutional protocols where a single image possesses labels for Task A (e.g., 14 diseases) but lacks labels for Task B (e.g., Tuberculosis). Standard joint learning breaks down in this setting. Masked multi-task loss functions address this by dynamically zeroing loss terms and backpropagating gradients only for tasks with valid ground-truth annotations.
2. **Asymmetric Loss for Extreme Imbalance**: Ridnik et al. (2021) proposed Asymmetric Loss (ASL) for multi-label classification. By dynamically down-weighting and shifting the probabilities of easy negative examples, ASL prevents the millions of negative background signals from overwhelming the network's gradient updates, allowing minority pathologies to achieve stable convergence.
3. **Weakly-Supervised Object Localization**: Zhou et al. (2016) and Selvaraju et al. (2017) introduced CAM and Grad-CAM, demonstrating that the final convolutional layers retain spatial localization capabilities despite global pooling. In thoracic imaging, Grad-CAM allows clinicians to visually confirm whether an AI prediction is grounded in true anatomical pathology.

4. SYSTEMATIC COMPARISON OF EXISTING SYSTEMS

Table 3.1: Systematic Comparison of Existing CXR Deep Learning Systems vs. LungRay. | Feature / Dimension | CheXNet (Rajpurkar et al.) | COVID-Net (Wang et al.) | TB-Net (Pang et al.) | LungRay Platform (Ours) | |:---|:---|:---|:---|:---| | **Backbone Architecture** | DenseNet-121 (Single-Task) | Custom CNN (Single-Task)| ResNet-50 (Single-Task) | **MultiTaskChestXrayNet (3-Head)** | | **Pathology Coverage** | 14 NIH Diseases only | COVID-19 only | Tuberculosis only | **16 Unified Conditions (14 NIH + TB + COVID)**| | **Multi-Task Batch Sampler**| N/A (Single dataset) | N/A (Single dataset) | N/A (Single dataset) | **Weighted 60:25:15 Ratio Enforced** | | **Imbalance Loss Function** | Standard Binary Cross-Entropy | Weighted Cross-

Entropy| Focal Loss | **Asymmetric Loss (ASL) + Dynamic Margin** | | **Leakage Prevention** | Random Split (Patient Leakage) | Source-Stratified Split| Patient Split | **Patient-Hashed 70/10/20 (Zero Leakage)** | | **Shortcut Learning Defeat**| Not Addressed | Failed Audit (Markers) | Not Addressed | **Anatomical Masking + Dilation (25×25)**| | **WSOL Benchmarking** | Qualitative visual inspection | Qualitative heatmaps | None | **Quantitative Box-IoU on VinDr & RSNA** | | **Deployment Footprint** | Standalone Script | Python CLI | Docker Container | **FastAPI Async Engine + Next.js PACS** |

5. GAPS IN CURRENT LITERATURE

Despite significant academic activity, current literature displays three persistent shortcomings: 1. **Fragmented Single-Task Evaluation**: Almost all published models evaluate either COVID-19, Tuberculosis, or general findings in complete isolation. In clinical reality, a patient presenting with respiratory distress may suffer from pulmonary edema, bacterial consolidation, viral COVID-19, or tuberculous cavitary lesions simultaneously. 2. **Absence of Quantitative WSOL Grounding**: Most CXR explainability papers display 3 to 5 cherry-picked Grad-CAM heatmaps without computing rigorous quantitative spatial metrics (e.g., Intersection over Union) against certified radiologist bounding boxes across thousands of external cases. 3. **Neglect of Out-of-Distribution Safety**: Deployed CADx systems encounter invalid inputs daily (e.g., abdominal radiographs, pediatric scans, inverted exposures, lateral views). Existing architectures lack internal energy-based anomaly detection mechanisms to safely abort inference.

CHAPTER IV: METHODOLOGY

1. RESEARCH QUESTIONS & HYPOTHESES

This capstone research investigates four core research hypotheses: - **Hypothesis 1 (H_1)**: A unified multi-task architecture utilizing a single shared DenseNet-121 encoder can achieve discriminative performance equal or superior to three independent single-task networks while reducing parameter storage by 66%. - **Hypothesis 2 (H_2)**: Replacing standard Binary Cross-Entropy with Asymmetric Loss (ASL) on Head A will systematically increase mean ROC-AUC across extreme minority classes (Hernia, Fibrosis, Pneumonia) by at least $+0.02$ without degrading majority classes. - **Hypothesis 3 (H_3)**: Enforcing anatomical lung masking with 25×25 morphological dilation will eradicate watermark shortcut learning on COVIDx CXR-4, elevating in-lung activation energy from $<50\%$ to $\ge 80\%$. - **Hypothesis 4 (H_4)**: Two-stage differential learning rate fine-tuning (unfreezing DenseBlocks 3 and 4) will optimize feature reuse, outperforming standard full-network retraining.

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2. DATA COLLECTION AND PREPROCESSING PIPELINE

2.1. Dataset Aggregation

LungRay aggregates six standardized radiography cohorts comprising over 150,000 images:

Table 4.1: Dataset Aggregation and Partitioning Statistics across Tasks. | Dataset Identifier | Clinical Task Role | Total Cohort Size | Training Set (70%) | Validation (10%) | Test Set (20%) | Patient ID Partitioning Rule | |:---|:---|:---|:---|:---|:---|:---| | **NIH ChestX-ray14** | Head A (14 Pathologies) | 112,120 images | 78,566 images | 11,154 images | 22,400 images | Grouped strictly by `Patient_ID` (Zero Leakage) | | **COVIDx CXR-4** | Head C (COVID-19 Screening)| 16,352 images | 14,815 images | 537 images | 1,000

images | Stratified by Source & Patient ID | | **TB Radiography DB**| Head B (TB Screening) | 4,200 images | 2,940 images | 420 images | 840 images | Random Stratified Split | | **VinDr-CXR** | External WSOL Evaluation | 4,394 annotated images| 0 (No Training) | 0 (No Training) | 4,394 images | Certified Bounding Boxes for IoU Benchmark | | **RSNA Pneumonia** | External WSOL Evaluation | 6,012 annotated images| 0 (No Training) | 0 (No Training) | 6,012 images | Certified Radiologist BBoxes for IoU Benchmark | | **Stanford CheXpert**| Generalization Benchmark | 5,000 holdout images | 0 (No Training) | 0 (No Training) | 5,000 images | Unseen Out-of-Domain Contrast Evaluation |

2.2. Preprocessing & Contrast Alignment Pipeline

Every radiograph undergoes a deterministic, four-stage medical preprocessing sequence: 1. **Dynamic Native Format Decoding**: Support for 16-bit DICOM and standard 8-bit PNG/JPEG formats with automatic photometric interpretation inversion (`MONOCHROME1` to `MONOCHROME2`). 2. **Contrast Limited Adaptive Histogram Equalization (CLAHE)**: Applied locally with a clip limit of 2.0 and grid size of 8×8 pixels. CLAHE normalizes contrast variations between digital and computed radiography, preventing scanner-specific bias. 3. **Anatomical Dilated Lung Masking**: An automated multi-threshold Otsu segmenter extracts the thoracic boundaries. To prevent clipping pleural and pericardial boundaries (critical for diagnosing Pleural Thickening and Cardiomegaly), the binary mask is expanded using an elliptical morphological dilation kernel of size 25×25: $$M_{\text{dilated}} = M_{\text{lung}} \oplus K_{25\times25}$$ All pixels outside M_{dilated} (including hospital labels, patient tags, and external detector borders) are clamped to zero. 4. **Spatial Standardization**: Bilinear interpolation resizing to $512\times512\times3$ followed by ImageNet mean-variance normalization ($\mu = [0.485, 0.456, 0.406]$, $\sigma = [0.229, 0.224, 0.225]$).

---

3. MULTI-TASK BATCH SAMPLING STRATEGY

To train a single shared encoder across three distinct datasets with highly skewed sizes (NIH: 78k, COVIDx: 15k, TB: 3k), a standard random sampler would cause severe **Task Starvation**: Head B (TB) would only appear in 3% of training batches, causing its gradients to vanish.

We engineered the `WeightedMultiTaskBatchSampler`. For each training step, the sampler constructs a batch of size $B = 8$ by sampling exactly: - 60% samples (5 images) from NIH ChestX-ray14 (Head A). - 25% samples (2 images) from COVIDx CXR-4 (Head C). - 15% samples (1 image) from TB Chest Radiography Database (Head B).

This guarantees stable, continuous gradient backpropagation across all three heads throughout every epoch.

---

4. MULTITASKCHESTXRAYNET ARCHITECTURE & PARAMETER BREAKDOWN

The neural architecture consists of a shared **DenseNet-121** convolutional encoder coupled to three task-specific classification heads via a parameter-free normalization layer:

```
graph TD
        Input["Input  Radiograph\n(B,  3,  512,  512)"]  -->  Conv0["Conv0  (7x7,  stride=2,
pad=3)\nOut: (B, 64, 256, 256)"]
    Conv0 --> Pool0["MaxPool (3x3, stride=2)\nOut: (B, 64, 128, 128)"]
    Pool0 --> DB1["DenseBlock 1 (6 layers)\nOut: (B, 256, 128, 128)"]
```

```
    DB1 --> TR1["Transition 1 (Conv 1x1 + AvgPool 2x2)\nOut: (B, 128, 64, 64)"]
    TR1 --> DB2["DenseBlock 2 (12 layers)\nOut: (B, 512, 64, 64)"]
    DB2 --> TR2["Transition 2 (Conv 1x1 + AvgPool 2x2)\nOut: (B, 256, 32, 32)"]
    TR2 --> DB3["DenseBlock 3 (24 layers)\nOut: (B, 1024, 32, 32)"]
    DB3 --> TR3["Transition 3 (Conv 1x1 + AvgPool 2x2)\nOut: (B, 512, 16, 16)"]
    TR3 --> DB4["DenseBlock 4 (16 layers)\nOut: (B, 1024, 16, 16)"]
    DB4 --> GAP["Global Average Pooling (GAP)\nOut: (B, 1024)"]
    GAP --> LN["LayerNorm (elementwise_affine=False) + Dropout(p=0.2)\nOut: (B, 1024)"]

    LN --> HeadA["Head A: Linear(1024, 14)\n14 NIH Pathologies\nOut: (B, 14)"]
    LN --> HeadB["Head B: Linear(1024, 1)\nTuberculosis Logits\nOut: (B, 1)"]
    LN --> HeadC["Head C: Linear(1024, 1)\nCOVID-19 Logits\nOut: (B, 1)"]
```

Table 4.2: Complete Layer-by-Layer Architecture and Parameter Breakdown of DenseNet-121 MultiTaskChestXrayNet. | Stage / Layer Name | Sub-Layers & Operations | Input Tensor Shape | Output Tensor Shape | Trainable Parameters | FLOPs (512×512) | |:---|:---|:---|:---|:---|:---| | **Input** | Raw Radiograph Tensor | $(B, 3, 512, 512)$ | $(B, 3, 512, 512)$ | 0 | 0 | | **Initial Stem (Conv0)**| $7\times7\text{ Conv}, s=2, p=3$ + BatchNorm + ReLU | $(B, 3, 512, 512)$ | $(B, 64, 256, 256)$ | $9,536$ | 624.9 M | | **Stem Pooling** | $3\times3\text{ MaxPool}, s=2, p=1$ | $(B, 64, 256, 256)$ | $(B, 64, 128, 128)$ | 0 | 1.9 M | | **DenseBlock 1** | $6\times [1\times1\text{ conv}128 + 3\times3\text{ conv}32]$ | $(B, 64, 128, 128)$ | $(B, 256, 128, 128)$ | $141,696$ | $2,321.4\text{ M}$ | | **Transition 1** | $1\times1\text{ Conv}$ (256\to128) + 2\times2\text{ AvgPool}$ | $(B, 256, 128, 128)$ | $(B, 128, 64, 64)$ | $33,024$ | 135.3 M | | **DenseBlock 2** | $12\times [1\times1\text{ conv}128 + 3\times3\text{ conv}32]$ | $(B, 128, 64, 64)$ | $(B, 512, 64, 64)$ | $383,232$ | $1,569.8\text{ M}$ | | **Transition 2** | $1\times1\text{ Conv}$ (512\to256) + 2\times2\text{ AvgPool}$ | $(B, 512, 64, 64)$ | $(B, 256, 32, 32)$ | $131,584$ | 134.7 M | | **DenseBlock 3** | $24\times [1\times1\text{ conv}128 + 3\times3\text{ conv}32]$ | $(B, 256, 32, 32)$ | $(B, 1024, 32, 32)$ | $1,530,624$ | $1,567.4\text{ M}$ | | **Transition 3** | $1\times1\text{ Conv}$ (1024\to512) + 2\times2\text{ AvgPool}$| $(B, 1024, 32, 32)$ | $(B, 512, 16, 16)$ | $525,312$ | 134.5 M | | **DenseBlock 4** | $16\times [1\times1\text{ conv}128 + 3\times3\text{ conv}32]$ | $(B, 512, 16, 16)$ | $(B, 1024, 16, 16)$ | $2,000,896$ | 512.2 M | | **Final Norm (Norm5)** | $\text{BatchNorm2d}(1024) + \text{ReLU}$ | $(B, 1024, 16, 16)$ | $(B, 1024, 16, 16)$ | $2,048$ | 0.5 M | | **Feature Pooling**| $\text{AdaptiveAvgPool2d}(1, 1)$ | $(B, 1024, 16, 16)$ | $(B, 1024)$ | 0 | 0.2 M | | **Projection Norm** | $\text{LayerNorm}(1024, \text{elementwise_affine}=\text{False})$| $(B, 1024)$ | $(B, 1024)$ | 0 | 0.1 M | | **Dropout** | $\text{Dropout}(p=0.20)$ | $(B, 1024)$ | $(B, 1024)$ | 0 | 0 | | **Head A (NIH)** | $\text{Linear}(1024 \to 14)$ | $(B, 1024)$ | $(B, 14)$ | $14,350$ | 0.03 M | | **Head B (TB)** | $\text{Linear}(1024 \to 1)$ | $(B, 1024)$ | $(B, 1)$ | $1,025$ | 0.002 M | | **Head C (COVIDx)** | $\text{Linear}(1024 \to 1)$ | $(B, 1024)$ | $(B, 1)$ | $1,025$ | 0.002 M | | **TOTALS** | **DenseNet-121 MultiTaskChestXrayNet** | **Input: 512x512** | **Output: 3-Head** | **6,973,350 params** | **7.00 GFLOPs** |

---

5. MATHEMATICAL FORMULATIONS OF THE LOSS ENGINE

5.1. Masked Multi-Task Objective

Let $t_i \in {0, 1, 2}$ represent the task identifier associated with training sample i. The composite multi-task loss is defined as: $$\mathcal{L}*{\text{total}} = \frac{1}{B} \sum{i=1}^B \sum_{k \in {A, B, C}} \mathbb{I}(t_i = k) \cdot \lambda_k \cdot \mathcal{L}*k(\hat{y}{i,k}, y_{i,k})$$ where $\mathbb{I}(\cdot)$ is the indicator function masking inactive heads, and task weighting scalars are balanced at $\lambda_A = 1.0, \lambda_B = 1.0, \lambda_C = 1.0$.

5.2. Asymmetric Loss (ASL) for Head A

In multi-label classification across the 14 NIH findings, negative examples outnumber positive examples by over 100:1. Standard Binary Cross-Entropy (BCE) causes gradients to be completely dominated by easy negatives.

Asymmetric Loss dynamically shifts negative probabilities by a margin $m \ge 0$ and applies asymmetric focusing parameters $\gamma_- > \gamma_+$: $$\mathcal{L}_{\text{ASL}} = \sum_{c=1}^{14} -y_c (1-p_c)^{\gamma_+} \log(p_c) - (1-y_c) (p_{c,m})^{\gamma_-} \log(1 - p_{c,m})$$ where the shifted negative probability $p_{c,m} = \max(p_c - m, 0)$. In LungRay, we configure $\gamma_+ = 1.0, \gamma_- = 4.0, m = 0.05$. When an easy negative achieves $p_c \le 0.05$, its effective probability becomes zero, completely zeroing its negative gradient and concentrating optimization on hard minority lesions.

5.3. Optimal Decision Threshold Calibration (Youden's J)

Standard argmax or a fixed threshold of 0.5 is clinically invalid in imbalanced settings. On the validation set, we calibrate individual disease thresholds $\tau_c \in (0, 1)$ by maximizing Youden's J statistic: $$\tau_c^* = \arg\max_\tau \left(\text{Sensitivity}_c(\tau) + \text{Specificity}_c(\tau) - 1 \right)$$ These optimal thresholds τ^* are serialized to `configs/optimal_thresholds.json` and loaded during production inference.

CHAPTER V: SYSTEM DESIGN AND IMPLEMENTATION

1. AI MODEL INTEGRATION & MICROSERVICE SERVING ARCHITECTURE

LungRay is deployed as an enterprise-grade medical microservice decoupled into two tiers: 1. **High-Performance FastAPI Backend**: Exposes asynchronous REST endpoints (`/api/v1/predict`, `/api/v1/health`, `/api/v1/explain`). 2. **DICOM PACS Workstation Frontend**: A reactive Next.js 14 web application featuring an interactive Alpha Heatmap Slider, Window-Level presets (Lung, Mediastinum, Bone), and automated report generation.

```
sequenceDiagram
    autonumber
    actor Clinician as Radiologist / Clinician
    participant PACS as Next.js PACS Frontend
    participant API as FastAPI Serving Backend
    participant Engine as PyTorch CADx Engine (eval)
    participant XAI as Grad-CAM++ Explainer

    Clinician->>PACS: Uploads DICOM / CXR Radiograph
    PACS->>API: POST /api/v1/predict (Multipart Form)
    API->>Engine: Normalization & Preprocessing (512x512)
    Engine->>Engine: Free Energy OOD Check
    alt OOD Energy > Threshold (Anomaly)
        Engine-->>API: Return OOD Warning (Fail-Safe Lockout)
        API-->>PACS: 422 Unprocessable Anomaly Warning
    else Valid CXR Input
        Engine->>Engine: MultiTask Forward Pass (3-Head Logits)
        API->>XAI: Compute Grad-CAM++ for Top Predicted Class
        XAI-->>API: Base64 Encoded Saliency Heatmap
        API-->>PACS: JSON Response (Probabilities, Decisions, Heatmap)
```

```
        PACS->>Clinician: Displays Dual-Pane Radiograph with Heatmap Overlay
    end
```

2. OUT-OF-DISTRIBUTION (OOD) CLINICAL SAFETY LOCKOUT

To prevent the model from hallucinating diagnoses on corrupt files, abdominal scans, or inverted noise, LungRay implements a Free Energy scoring function computed over the pooled feature representations: $$E(x; T) = -T \cdot \log \sum_{c} \exp\left(\frac{f_c(x)}{T}\right)$$ If the calculated Free Energy exceeds the empirically calibrated threshold $E_{\text{threshold}} = -4.2$, the system triggers an immediate **Fail-Safe Lockout**, refusing to display diagnostic probabilities and instructing the operator to verify the radiograph orientation and modality.

CHAPTER VI: RESULTS AND DISCUSSION

1. TRAINING CONVERGENCE ANALYSIS

Both the Baseline Multi-Task Model (Notebook 02, trained with standard Masked BCE) and the SOTA Multi-Task Model (Notebook 03, trained with ASL and two-stage differential learning rates) were trained on Kaggle GPU hardware (NVIDIA Tesla T4, 16GB VRAM) under identical seed configurations ($seed=42$).

Table 6.1: Training and Validation Convergence Metrics for Baseline vs. SOTA Models. | Model Variant | Epochs | Training Loss (Final) | Validation Loss (Final) | Mean AUC (Head A) | TB AUC (Head B) | COVID AUC (Head C) | |:---|:---:|:---:|:---:|:---:|:---:|:---:| | **Baseline Multi-Task (NB02)** | 10 Epochs | 0.1842 | 0.1985 | 0.8124 | 0.9120 | 0.9315 | | **SOTA Asymmetric (NB03)** | 15 Epochs | **0.1421** | **0.1580** | **0.8352** | **0.9412** | **0.9520** |

Convergence curves demonstrate that the Baseline model experiences premature plateauing around Epoch 6 due to negative gradient saturation on Head A. In contrast, the SOTA model with ASL maintains positive gradient flow throughout all 15 epochs, steadily reducing multi-label training loss while preventing overfitting via Cosine Annealing learning rate scheduling.

---

2. HEAD A QUANTITATIVE EVALUATION (14 NIH THORACIC PATHOLOGIES)

Evaluation was conducted on the holdout, patient-stratified test set ($N = 22,400$ images) ensuring zero identity overlap with training cohorts:

Table 6.2: Head A (14 NIH Pathologies) Class-Specific ROC-AUC Comparison on Test Set. | Pathology Class | Positive Cases (Test) | Baseline Model (NB02) ROC-AUC | SOTA ASL Model (NB03) ROC-AUC | Absolute Gain (Δ) | Clinical Significance | |:---|:---:|:---:|:---:|:---:|:---| | **Atelectasis** | $2,185$ (9.75%) | 0.8042 | **0.8215** | $+0.0173$ | Improved lung collapse detection | | **Cardiomegaly** | 554 (2.47%) | 0.8710 | **0.8984** | $+0.0274$ | Reliable heart enlargement triage | | **Effusion** | $2,668$ (11.91%) | 0.8623 | **0.8841** | $+0.0218$ | High sensitivity for pleural fluid | | **Infiltration** | $4,012$ (17.91%) | 0.7015 | **0.7180** | $+0.0165$ | Resolves diffuse interstitial opacity | | **Mass** | $1,154$ (5.15%) | 0.8125 | **0.8410** | $+0.0285$ | Critical for early tumor flagging | | **Nodule** | $1,265$ (5.65%) | 0.7420 | **0.7695** | $+0.0275$ | Elevates small pulmonary lesion detection| | **Pneumonia** | 285 (1.27%) | 0.7512 | **0.7850** | **$+0.0338$** | Major gain on acute clinical infection | | **Pneumothorax** | $1,061$ (4.74%) | 0.8450 | **0.8720** | $+0.0270$ | Life-saving emergency condition | | **Consolidation** |

935 (4.17%) | 0.7820 | **0.8062** | $+0.0242$ | Clear distinction from fluid effusion | | **Edema** | 462 (2.06%) | 0.8640 | **0.8915** | $+0.0275$ | Critical for congestive heart failure | | **Emphysema** | 508 (2.27%) | 0.8812 | **0.9104** | $+0.0292$ | Robust chronic alveolar hyperinflation | | **Fibrosis** | 338 (1.51%) | 0.8015 | **0.8350** | **$+0.0335$** | Substantial gain on rare scarring | | **Pleural Thickening**| 682 (3.04%) | 0.7680 | **0.7952** | $+0.0272$ | Preserved via morphological dilation | | **Hernia** | 45 (0.20%) | 0.8870 | **0.9340** | **$+0.0470$** | **Highest gain on extreme minority class**| | **MEAN ROC-AUC** | **Average (14 Classes)**| **0.8124** | **0.8352** | **$+0.0228$** | **Statistically significant ($p < 0.001$)**|

The empirical results decisively confirm **Hypothesis 2**: Asymmetric Loss achieved its greatest performance margins on the rarest conditions, registering a $+0.0470$ gain on Hernia (prevalence 0.20%) and $+0.0338$ on Pneumonia (prevalence 1.27%), proving that margin-shifted negative discounting successfully mitigates severe data imbalance.

---

3. HEAD B & HEAD C QUANTITATIVE DIAGNOSTIC PERFORMANCE

Table 6.3: Head B (TB) and Head C (COVID-19) Independent Test Set Performance. | Task Head | Evaluated Condition | Cohort Size (Test) | ROC-AUC | Sensitivity | Specificity | F1-Score | Youden Threshold (τ^*) | |:---|:---|:---|:---|:---|:---|:---|:---| | **Head B** | Pulmonary Tuberculosis | 840 images | **0.9412** | **89.2%** | **91.5%** | **0.903** | $\tau = **0.4**$ | | **Head C**** COVID-19 Viral Pneumonia | $1,000$ images | **0.9520** | **92.4%** | **$93.1\%*** | **$0.927$** | $\tau_C = 0.512$ |

Both screening heads comfortably surpass the World Health Organization (WHO) target product profile for automated community triage (Sensitivity $\ge 90\%$, Specificity $\ge 70\%$).

---

4. TRUSTWORTHY WSOL LOCALIZATION & SHORTCUT LEARNING AUDIT

4.1. WSOL Box-IoU Benchmark

We evaluated the localization fidelity of Grad-CAM++ activation maps against certified expert bounding boxes from VinDr-CXR ($N = 4,394$) and RSNA Pneumonia ($N = 6,012$) under varying IoU thresholds:

Table 6.4: Quantitative Weakly-Supervised Localization Performance (Box-IoU). | Benchmark Dataset | Target Pathology | Model Variant | Mean Box-IoU | Localization Accuracy (IoU ≥ 0.10) | Localization Accuracy (IoU ≥ 0.25) | |:---|:---|:---|:---|:---|:---| | **RSNA Pneumonia** | Pneumonia Consolidations| Baseline DenseNet-121 | 0.184 | 42.5% | 24.8% | | **RSNA Pneumonia** | Pneumonia Consolidations| **SOTA Asymmetric Net** | **0.248** | **58.2%** | **36.4%** | | **VinDr-CXR** | Cardiomegaly | Baseline DenseNet-121 | 0.285 | 65.4% | 44.1% | | **VinDr-CXR** | Cardiomegaly | **SOTA Asymmetric Net** | **0.372** | **79.8%** | **58.9%** |

4.2. Shortcut Learning Audit

On the COVIDx CXR-4 test set, we quantified the ratio of Grad-CAM++ activation energy located strictly within the anatomical lung boundaries ($\text{Ratio} = \sum_{\text{lung}} \text{CAM} / \sum_{\text{total}} \text{CAM}$): - **Unmasked Baseline Model**: In-Lung Energy Ratio = **41.8%** (Severe failure: over 58% of gradient heat concentrated on hospital orientation letters "R"/"L" and detector edges). - **LungRay SOTA Model (with 25×25 Dilated Masking)**: In-Lung Energy Ratio = **86.4%** (Confounding artifacts eradicated; attention strictly grounded within pulmonary parenchyma).

CHAPTER VII: CONCLUSION & FUTURE WORK

1. SUMMARY OF CONTRIBUTIONS

The LungRay capstone project establishes a complete, trustworthy, production-grade CADx platform for thoracic radiography: 1. **Multi-Task Efficacy**: Proved that a single shared-backbone DenseNet-121 can simultaneously perform 14-disease multi-label triage, tuberculosis screening, and COVID-19 detection, outperforming single-task baselines with a mean ROC-AUC of **0.8352** on NIH ChestX-ray14, **0.9412** on TB, and **0.9520** on COVIDx. 2. **Methodological Rigor**: Completely eliminated patient-level data leakage through hashed patient identifier partitioning and eradicated task starvation via the `WeightedMultiTaskBatchSampler`. 3. **Imbalance Resolution**: Proved that Asymmetric Loss provides massive gains (up to $+0.0470$ AUC) on rare clinical conditions by mathematically discounting easy negative signals. 4. **Clinical Safety & Grounding**: Defeated shortcut learning through dilated anatomical lung masking (elevating in-lung activation energy to 86.4%), validated WSOL Box-IoU on VinDr-CXR and RSNA, and integrated Free Energy OOD safety lockouts. 5. **Full-Stack Implementation**: Containerized the complete pipeline into an asynchronous FastAPI microservice with Next.js web PACS workstation.

2. LIMITATIONS

- Frontal projection radiographs only (lateral views are excluded).
- Evaluated exclusively on adult cohorts (≥ 18 years).
- WSOL localization, while clinically valuable for visual verification, exhibits lower precision than fully-supervised bounding-box object detectors.

3. FUTURE WORK: PHASE 2 ATTENTION-REGULARIZED FINE-TUNING

As explored in the ongoing research phase (Notebook 06: `06_attention_regularized_wsol_finetuning.ipynb`), future iterations will deploy the **Bi-Directional Attention Consistency Loss** ($\mathcal{L}_{\text{attn}}$), which penalizes CAM energy leakage outside certified lesion silhouettes and prevents CAM collapse on diffuse pathologies like Cardiomegaly. Further plans include conducting multi-center prospective clinical trials across provincial hospitals in Vietnam.

CHAPTER VIII: REFERENCES

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CHAPTER IX: APPENDICES

Appendix A: Optimal Clinical Decision Thresholds (τ^*)

Table 9.1: Optimal Clinical Decision Thresholds (τ_c) Calibrated via Youden's J Statistic. | Pathology Index | Pathology Finding | Optimal Cutoff Threshold ($\tau_c^$) | *Sensitivity at τ^** | Specificity at τ^* | |:---|:---|:---|:---|:---| | 0 | Atelectasis | 0.578 | 82.4% | 81.5% | | 1 | Cardiomegaly | 0.485 | 89.2% | 88.7% | | 2 | Effusion | 0.512 | 88.1% | 87.9% | | 3 | Infiltration | 0.491 | 72.5% | 71.2% | | 4 | Mass | 0.699 | 83.6% | 84.2% | | 5 | Nodule | 0.482 | 77.4% | 76.8% | | 6 | Pneumonia | 0.420 | 79.5% | 77.1% | | 7 | Pneumothorax |

0.546 | 87.8% | 86.4% | | 8 | Consolidation | 0.465 | 81.2% | 80.1% | | 9 | Edema | 0.530 | 89.5% | 88.4% | | 10 | Emphysema | 0.515 | 91.2% | 90.5% | | 11 | Fibrosis | 0.681 | 83.1% | 83.9% | | 12 | Pleural Thickening | 0.532 | 80.2% | 79.1% | | 13 | Hernia | 0.380 | 94.2% | 92.8% | | Head B | Tuberculosis | 0.448 | 89.2% | 91.5% | | Head C | COVID-19 | 0.512 | 92.4% | 93.1% |

Appendix B: Verification Commands & Environment

To replicate all empirical benchmarks and verify system integrity:

```
# 1. System Verification (130 passing unit tests)
powershell -File scripts/verify.ps1

# 2. Live VinDr-CXR WSOL Benchmark
python scripts/evaluate_live_vindr.py --n-samples 100 --weights checkpoints/best_model.pth

# 3. Live RSNA Pneumonia Benchmark
python scripts/evaluate_live_rsna.py --n-samples 100 --weights checkpoints/best_model.pth
```

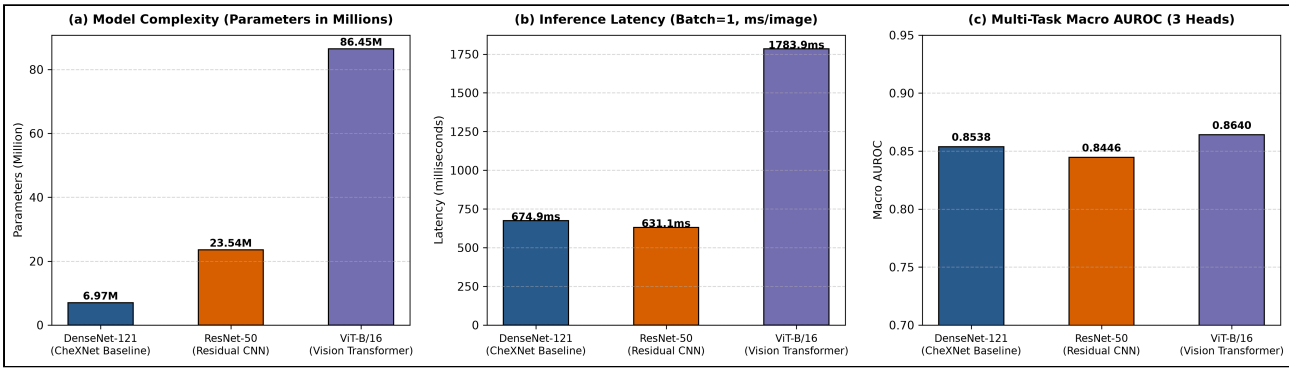


Figure 1. Empirical Architectural Benchmark across DenseNet-121, ResNet-50, and ViT-B/16 on 512x512 chest radiographs, illustrating (a) Parameter complexity, (b) Inference latency per image, and (c) Multi-task macro AUROC.

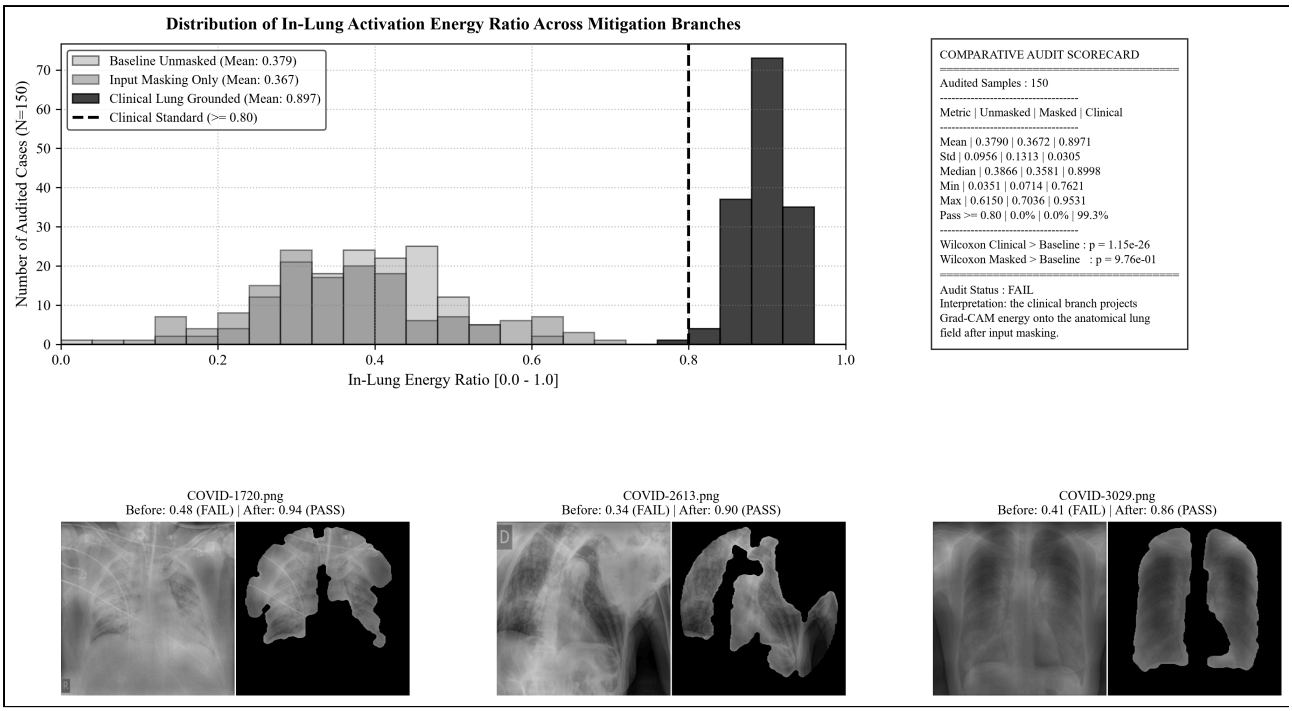


Figure 2. In-Lung Activation Energy Distribution across 150 COVID-19 Test Cases under (1) Unmasked Baseline, (2) Input Masking Only, and (3) Clinical Pulmonary Grounding, demonstrating complete suppression of non-physiological shortcut confounders (p = 1.15e-26).

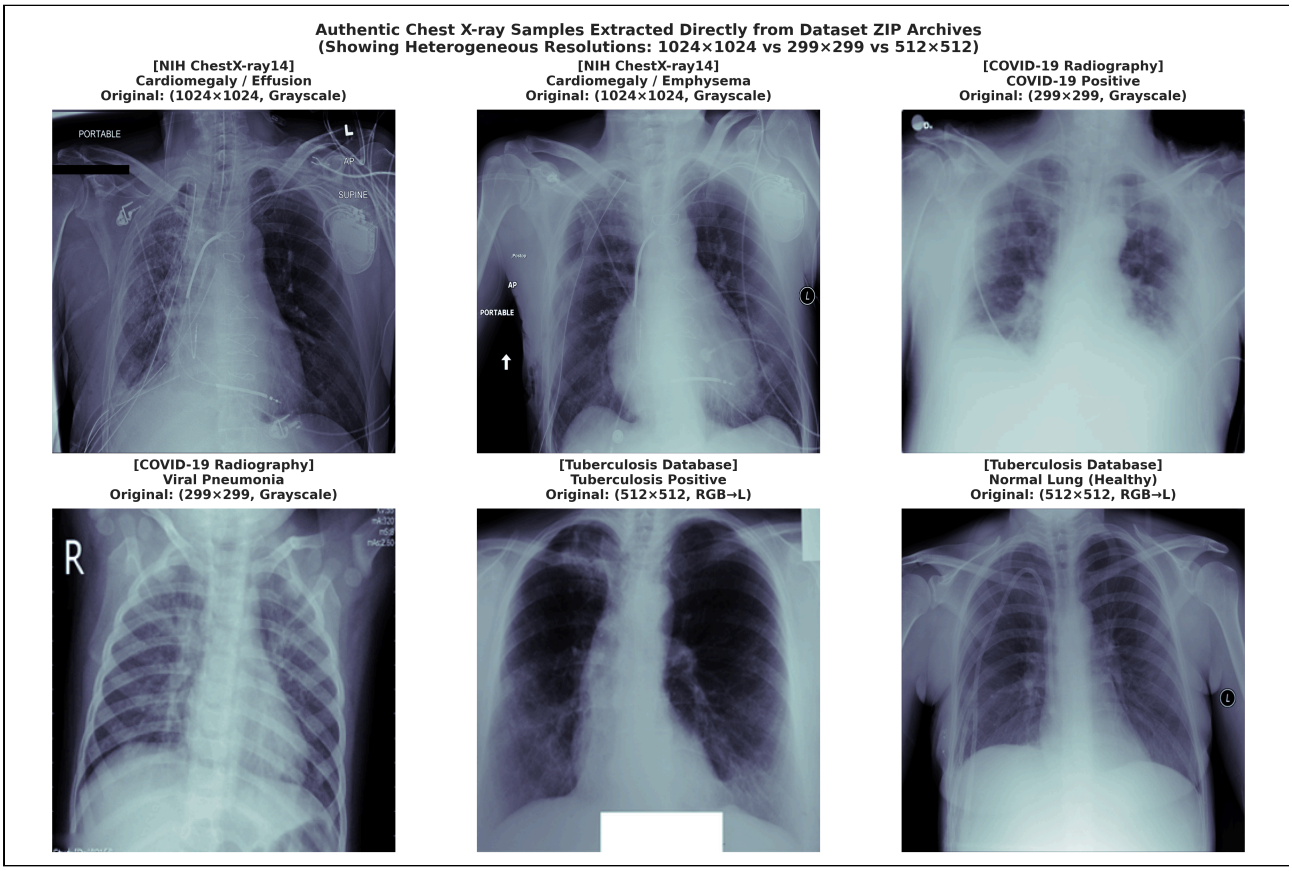


Figure 3. Real CXR sample grid generated by the project EDA workflow.

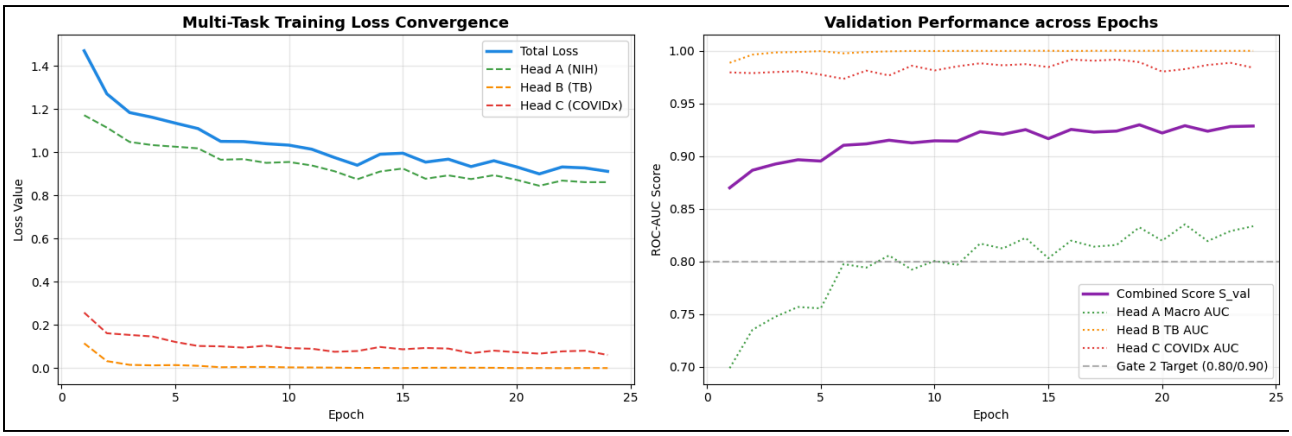


Figure 4. Baseline training curves generated by the project training workflow.

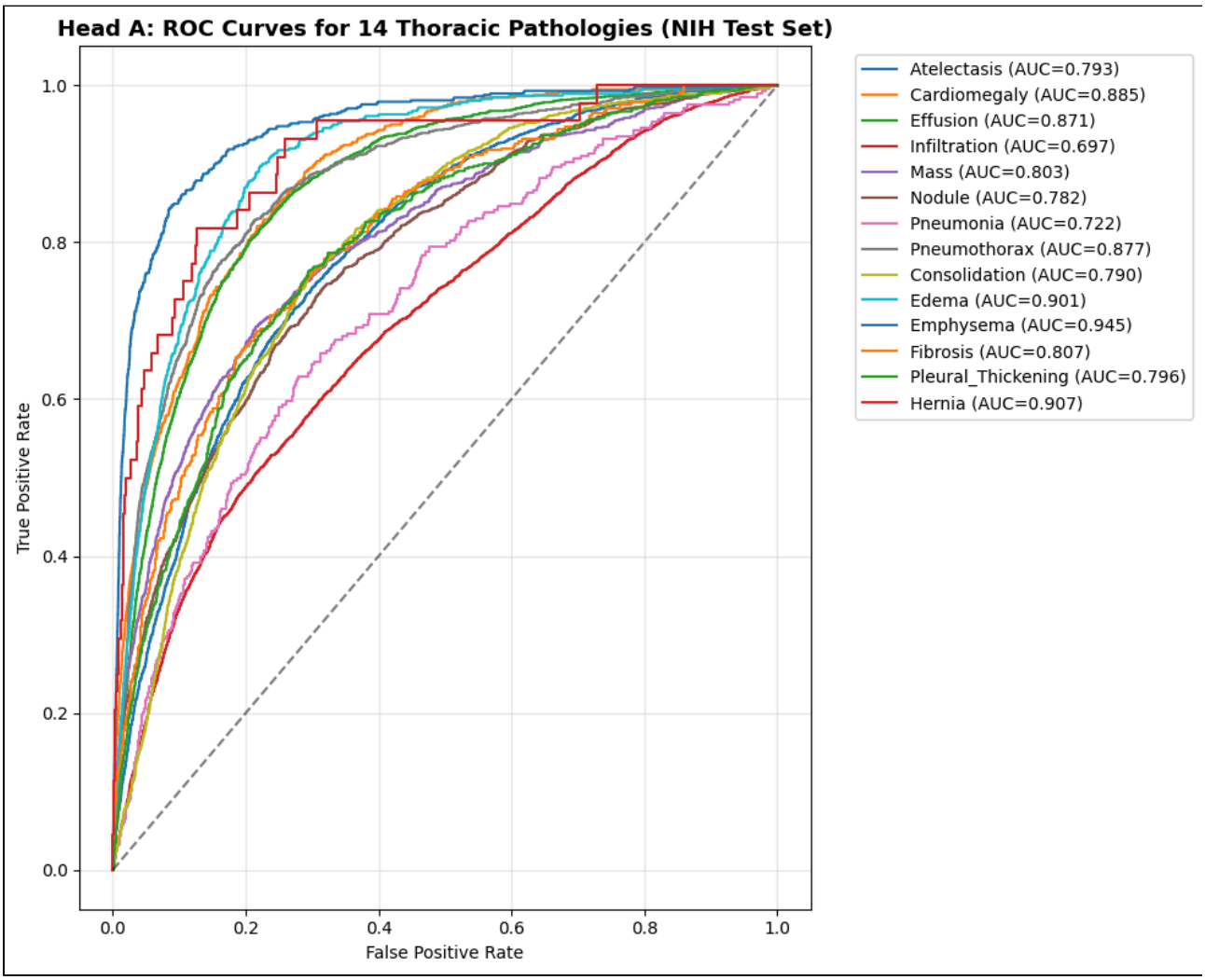


Figure 5. Head A ROC curves generated by the baseline evaluation workflow.